How to use Hope Beacon

An illustrated walk through the app, for the people using it

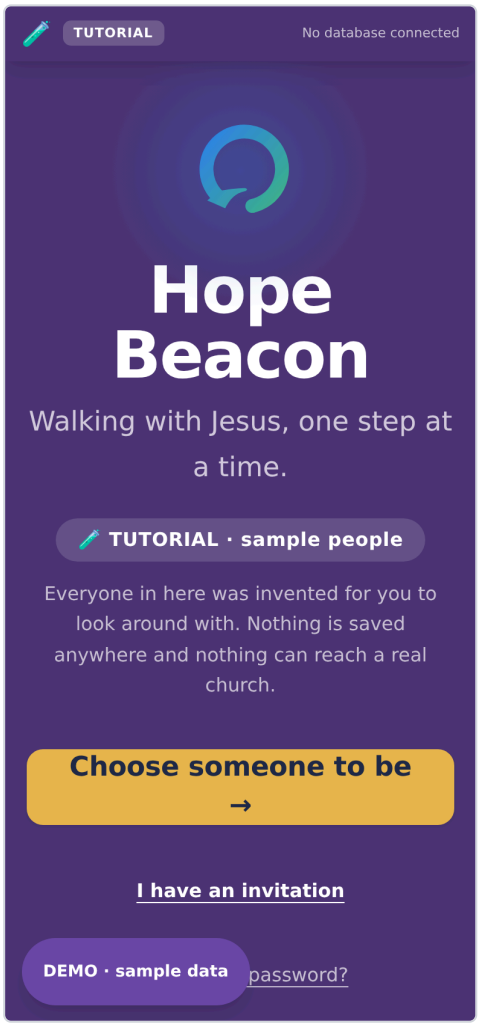
Every picture here is the real app, photographed on a phone-sized screen. Nothing is drawn or mocked up. The sample names you will see (John, Maria, Pastor Ramos) are the demo's own people, not anybody in your church.

If you only read one page, read **Part 2**. That is the whole app for most people.

Part 1 — Getting it on your phone

Hope Beacon is a website that behaves like an app. There is nothing to find in the App Store or Play Store, and nothing to pay for. You open a link once and then keep it on your home screen.

The link, and what you see first



The front door. Anybody can open this; it is the only page that does not need an account. I have an invitation is the way in.

Install it, so it opens like an app

Installing means the app gets its own icon, opens without the browser's address bar, and remembers you. It is the same app either way, only tidier.

On an iPhone or iPad (Safari)

1. Open the link in **Safari**. It has to be Safari; Chrome on an iPhone cannot install a web app.
2. Tap the **Share** button at the bottom of the screen (the square with an arrow coming out of the top).
3. Scroll down the list and tap **Add to Home Screen**.
4. Tap **Add**. The icon appears with your other apps.

On an Android phone (Chrome)

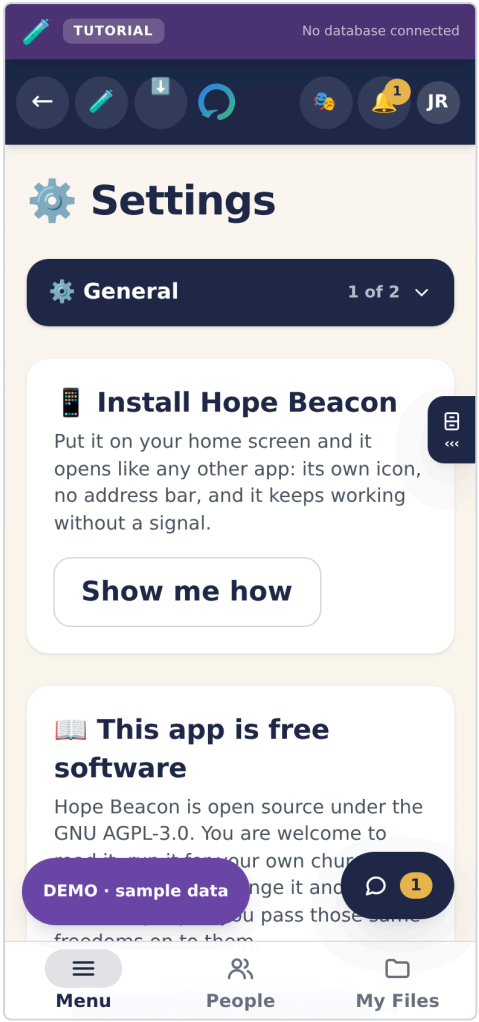
1. Open the link in **Chrome**.
2. Tap the **three dots** at the top right.
3. Tap **Add to Home screen**, then **Install**.

On a computer

Chrome and Edge show a small install icon at the right-hand end of the address bar. Safari on a Mac has **File → Add to Dock**.

> **If you are asked to sign in again after installing**, that is normal once. The installed copy starts its own session. It will remember you afterwards.

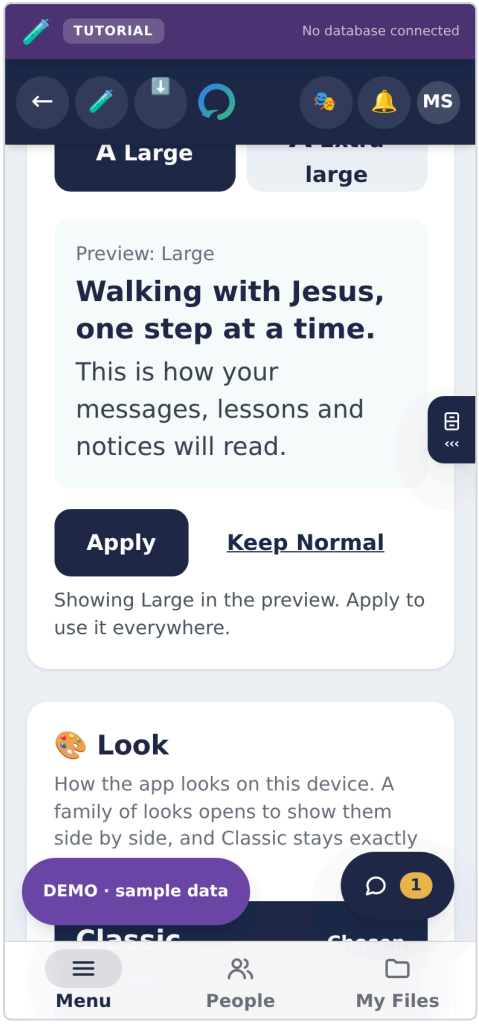
Everything to do with installing also lives inside the app, under Settings, so nobody has to keep this page to hand:



Settings. Installing, alerts, text size and language all live here, in the General folder.

Bigger words

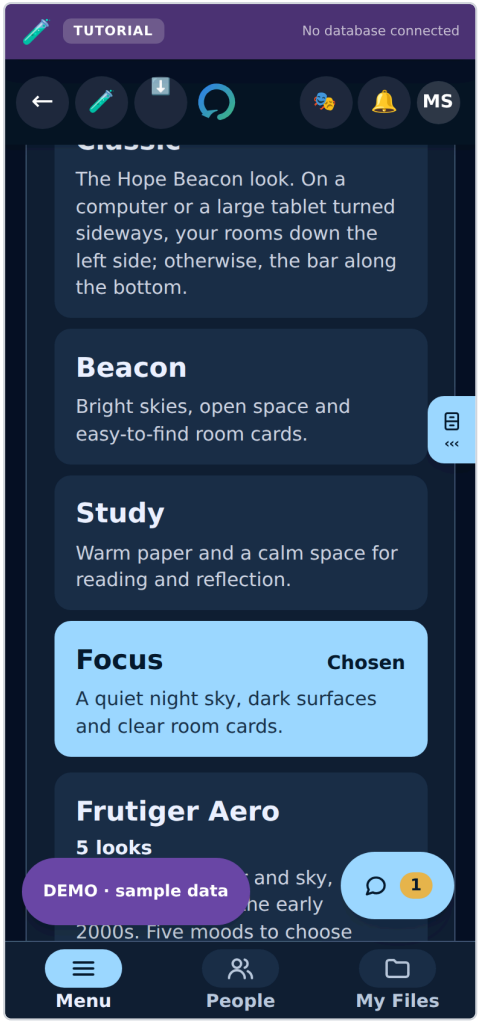
If the writing is too small, open **Settings**, stay in **General**, and choose a larger **Text size**. The preview below the sizes shows it first; when it reads well, press **Apply**, and every screen follows it, conversations included.



Text size. Large is tried in the preview; Apply makes it the size everywhere, Keep Normal leaves it as it was.

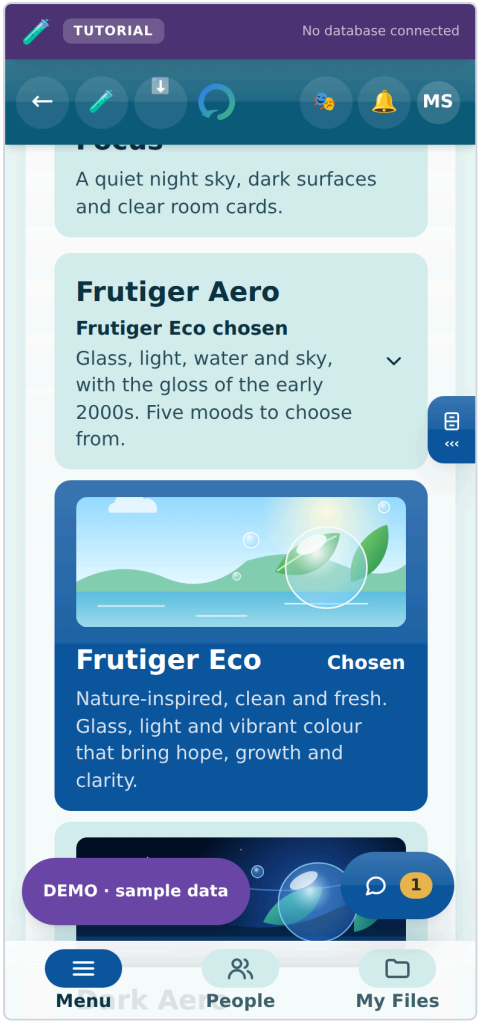
Just below it is **Look**, with **Classic** chosen. On a computer, and on a large iPad turned sideways, Classic has your rooms down the left side and a light bar across the top; on a phone or a smaller tablet, the bar along the bottom.

You can choose three other looks there: **Beacon** (bright and blue), **Study** (warm paper) and **Focus** (dark, like a night sky). The rooms and everything in them stay the same; only the colours and shapes change. The choice is kept on this phone or computer, and **Classic** takes you back.

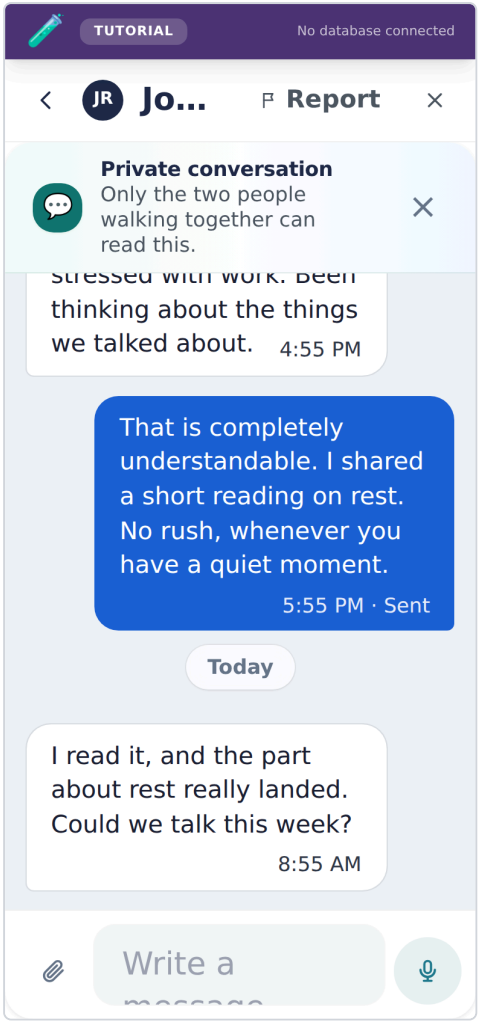


Look in Settings: Classic, Beacon, Study and Focus. Focus is chosen here.

Below them is **Frutiger Aero**, a row that opens to show five more looks, each with a picture and a line about it: **Frutiger Eco** (sky, water and leaves), **Dark Aero** (deep blue glass), **Technozen** (calm and minimal), **DORFic** (playful, early-2000s blue) and **Four Colors** (a bright colour for each room). Tap the row to open it, then tap the one you like.



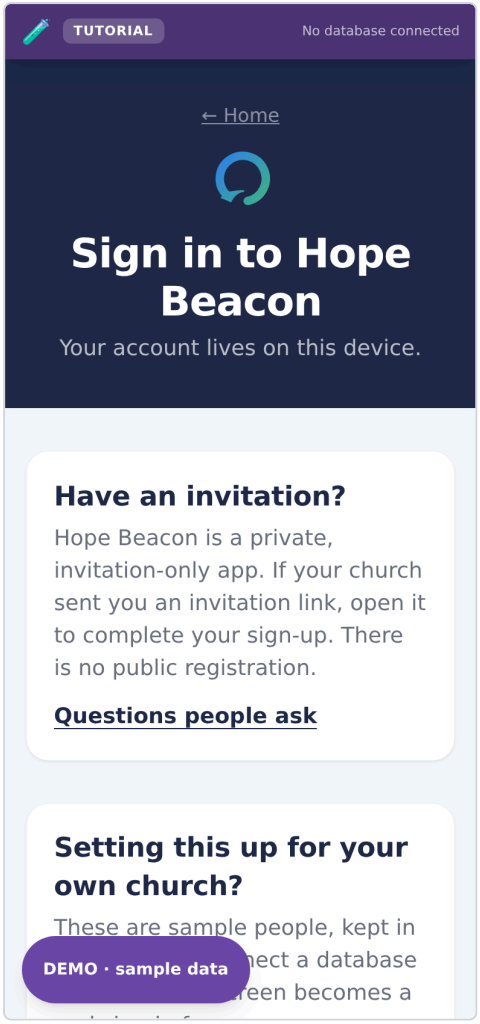
Frutiger Aero opened in Settings: five looks, each with its picture. Frutiger Eco is chosen here.



A conversation with Text size at its largest. The words grow and still fit the screen.

Signing in

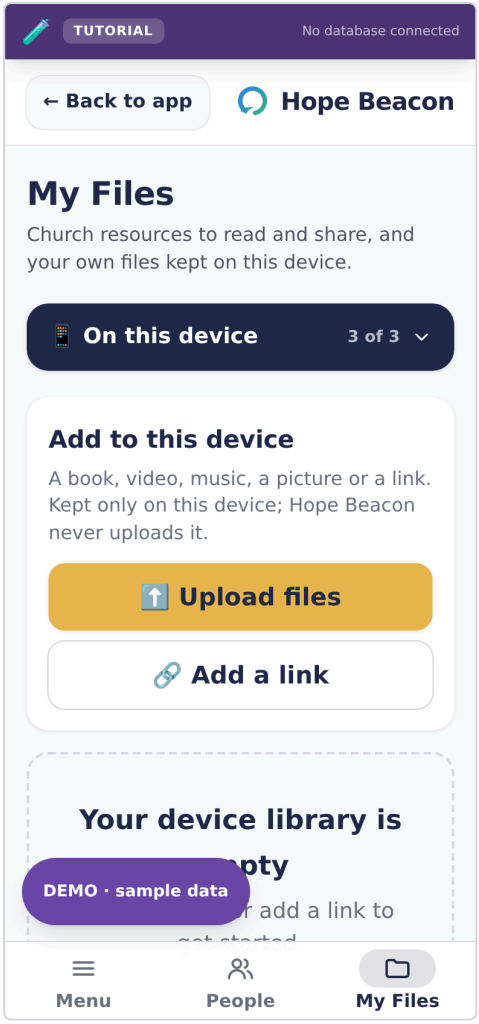
You need an invitation from your church. When you have one, you pick who you are and the app takes you to your own part of it.



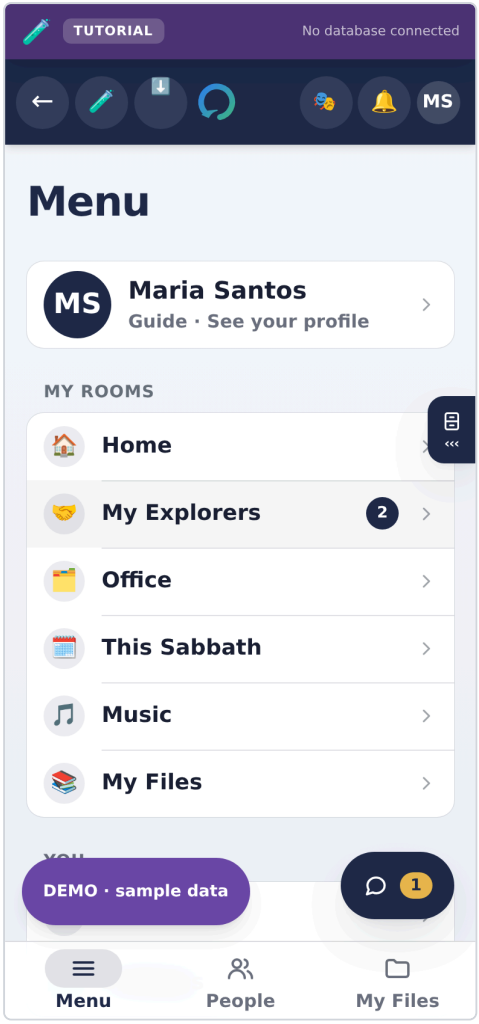
Signing in. There is no public sign-up: if you have no invitation yet, ask your church for one.

Finding your way

Along the bottom of every screen are three words. **Menu** lists every place you can go, written out. **People** opens the people you walk with. **My Files** opens the church's resources and your own files. On a phone or a pad, tap a chip under the search box (Bible study, Devotion and the rest) to narrow the list, and choose **On this device** for your own files: **Upload files** or **Add a link** at the top, and Delete asks a second time before anything goes.



My Files on a phone, On this device: Upload files and Add a link at the top, then your own files.



The Menu. Every room is written out, with your own profile at the top.

Some screens hold several **folders**. The button at the top names the one you are in and how many there are; tap it to see them all, then tap one to go there.



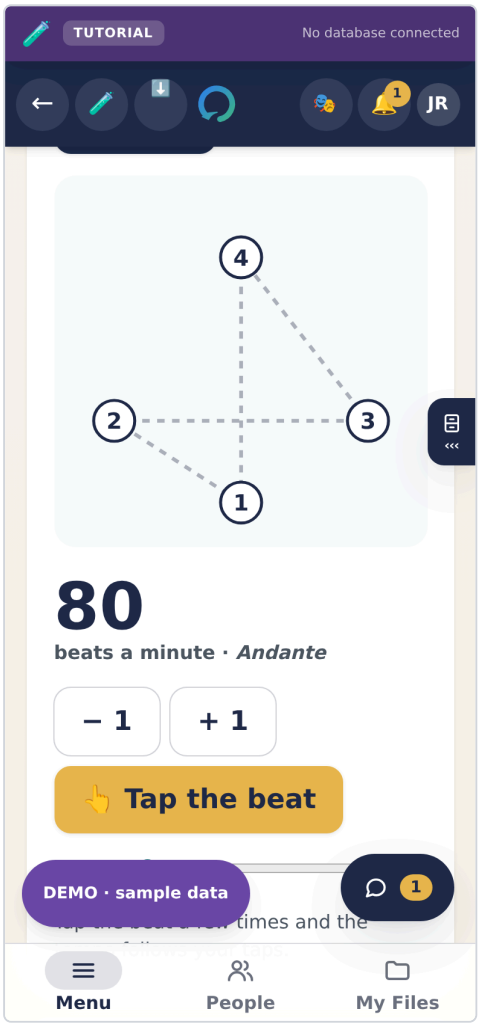
A folder list, open. It says you are in My Guide, 1 of 4, and lists the rest.

Music

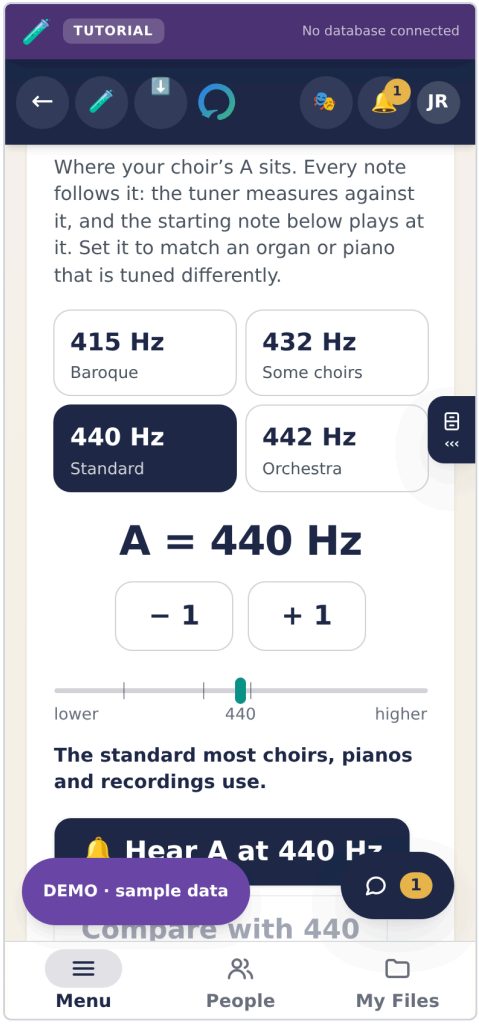
Music, in the Menu, is for everybody: the choir, and anybody who loves music. Everything in it happens on your phone, and nothing is sent anywhere. It has five folders. Each opens simple; tick **Advanced settings** at the end of a folder for more, and untick it to put the folder back as it was.

- **Listen** plays your own music and videos, in playlists if you like, and has calming sounds for the background. Your music is still in My Files as well, and each file there has its own Play button for a quick listen.
- **Tuner** tells you which note you are singing or playing and whether it is flat or sharp: the green band in the middle is in tune. Tap **Start listening**; your phone asks once whether the app may use the microphone. Tap **Stop listening** when you are done. It records nothing. **Starting note** plays a note for the choir, like a pitch pipe. **Concert pitch** is where the choir's A sits: 440 is the standard. Tap 442 or 432 and you hear the new A, with a line saying what it does to every note; **Compare with 440** plays the standard A, then yours. To match an organ or a piano, ask for its A and tap **Listen for the A**. In **Advanced**: **Sing the note**, a practice that shows you a note (or five to ten) and tells you whether you hit each one, with **Perfect pitch!** when you hit them all; a line drawing your voice over the last ten seconds, a **drone** to sing against, and the notes as a clarinet, trumpet, saxophone or horn reads them.

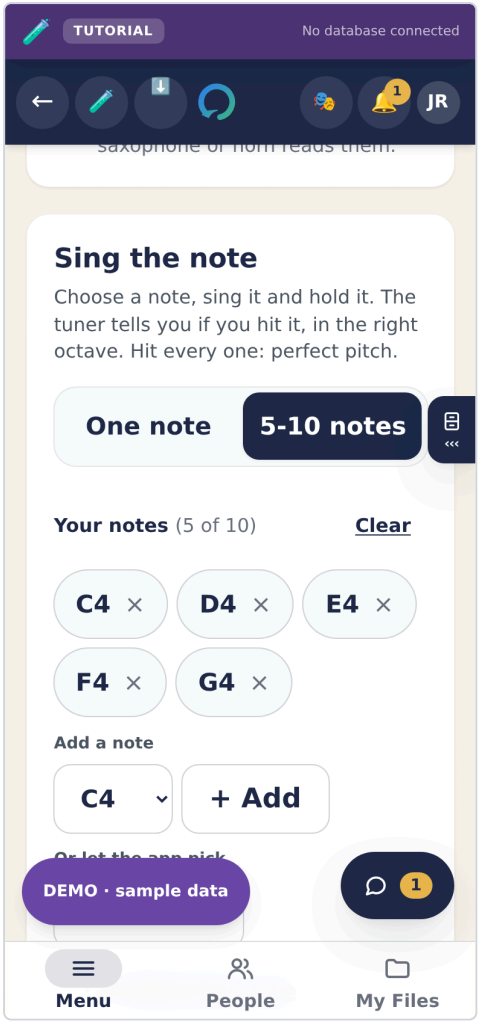
- **Conductor** keeps a steady beat and draws the conductor's hand for 2, 3, 4 or 6 beats. Tap **Tap the beat** a few times in time and the tempo follows you. Untick **Sound the clicks** to follow the hand in silence. In **Advanced**: clicks between the beats, loud or silent beats, a one-bar count-in, a speed trainer that gets a little faster bar by bar, and tempos saved by name, such as *Hymn 100*.
- **Pieces** keeps your choir's music. **Scan a page**: take a photo of a printed page, drag the four dots onto its corners, and tap **Make a clean page**. **Open a score or PDF**: a MusicXML file from MuseScore, Sibelius, Finale or Dorico, or a PDF that MuseScore or Dorico made, read note by note on the phone (check it against the page; a scanned PDF stays a picture). Choose **Your part** to hear it louder, slow it down, and tap the notes to start from anywhere. In **Advanced**: move it up or down to suit your voices, loop a hard passage, silence your own part to sing it, and choose the sound.
- **Play** is a piano keyboard: press and hold a key to hear it. In **Advanced**: the chords of any key a tap each, and a beat maker with a bass drum, snare and hi-hat, with your own beats saved by name.



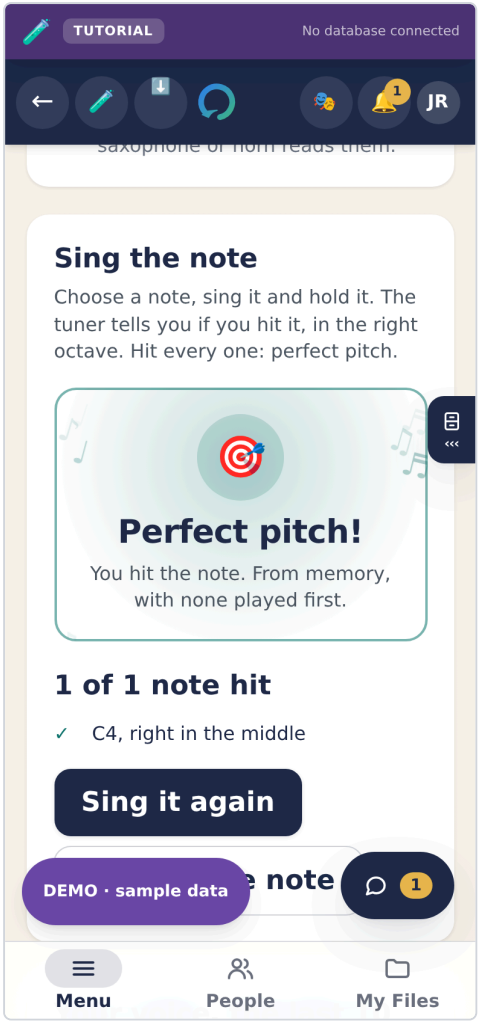
The Music room's Conductor. The pattern for four beats, numbered where the hand falls, with the tempo beside it.



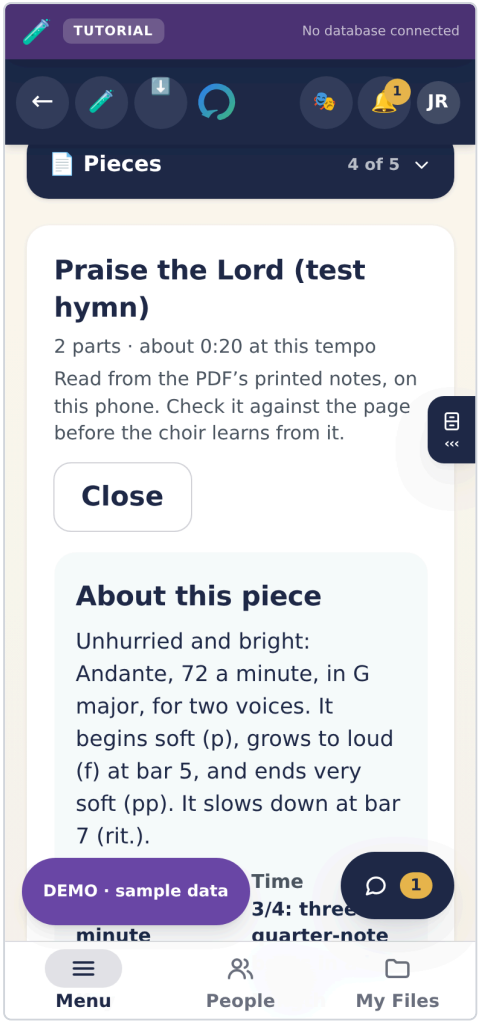
The Tuner's Concert pitch. One tap for each common A, the one chosen shown as chosen, and Compare with 440.



Sing the note, in the Tuner's Advanced settings: One note or 5-10 notes, the notes chosen, and a note to add.



C4 sung and held: a hit, and Perfect pitch.



Pieces with a choir PDF opened on the phone. Under the title it says it was read from the printed notes, and About this piece explains it.

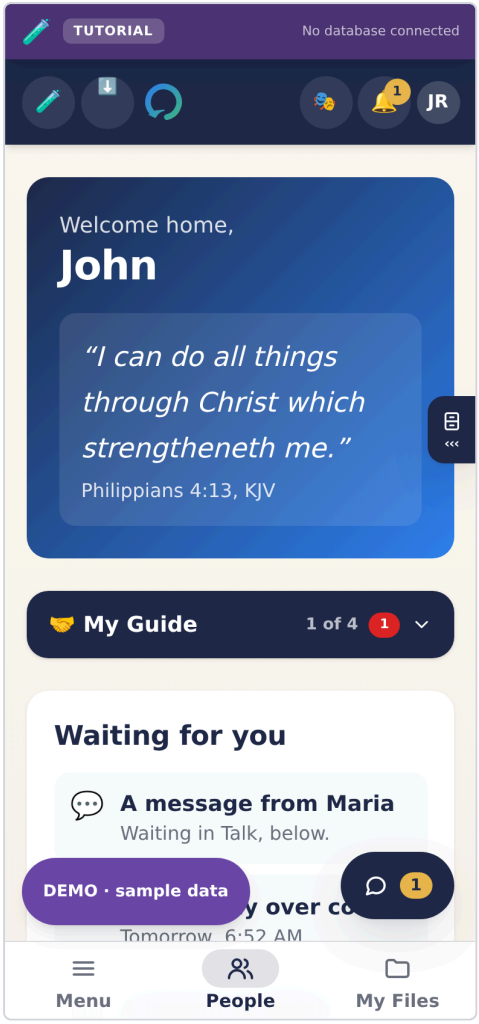
Part 2 — If you are an Explorer

An Explorer is somebody the church is walking with. You have one Guide, and the app is built around that one relationship.

Your screen has four folders: **My Guide**, **Study**, **Church** and **Prayer**. Tap the button at the top to go straight to one. You never have to scroll a long page looking for something.

My Guide

Your Guide, and anything waiting from them. Your conversation with them is the round **Talk** button in the corner of every screen, with a number on it when they have written. It is private between the two of you. Church leaders cannot read it.



My Guide. What is waiting for you, and a reminder of where the conversation is.

Talking with your Guide

Type in the box at the bottom and press the arrow. The paper clip sends a photo or a file.

Tap a message to react to it or reply to it. Holding it does the same.



Tap a message: six reactions along the top, then Reply and Copy. Edit and Delete appear on your own messages.

- **React** with one tap. The praying hands come first, because that is the one people reach for most. Tap the same one again to take it back.
- **Reply** to answer one message in particular. Your answer carries a quote of it. Swiping a message to the right does the same.



A reply, with the message it answers quoted above it. The praying hands under the earlier message are a reaction.

Say it instead of typing it. When the box is empty, the button beside it is a microphone. Tap it once and speak; the phone asks for the microphone the first time. Tap the arrow to send, or the bin to throw it away. It stops at two minutes and never sends on its own.



Recording a voice message. The clock counts while you speak; the bin throws it away, the arrow sends it.

> **If you do not see Reply, the reactions or the microphone**, your church has not switched them on yet. Everything else in the conversation works the same.

Study

The lessons your Guide has sent you, in the order they sent them. There is no schedule and nothing you are behind on. Open one, read it, and mark it done when you have finished.



Study. Your lessons, at your own pace.

Church

What the whole church is saying: notices, and anything the Guides have written for everybody. You can read it without owing anyone a reply.

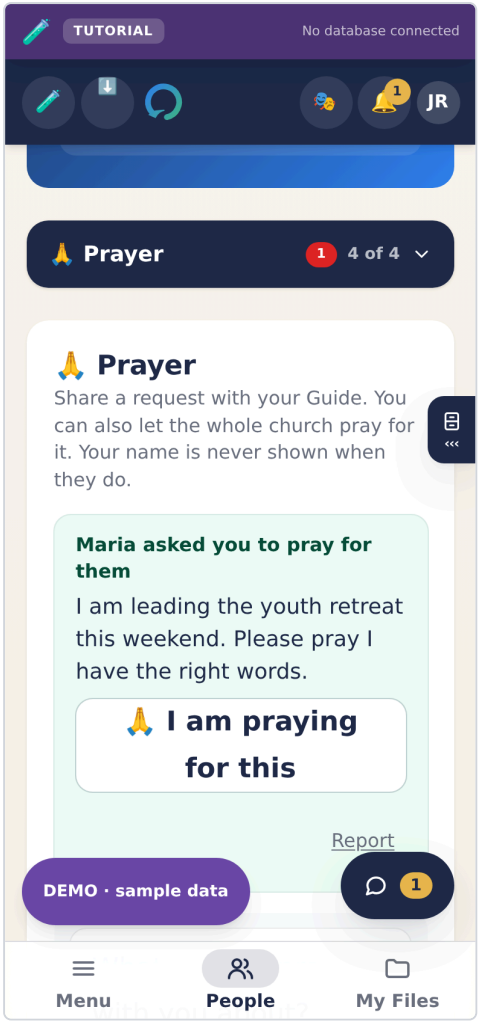


Church. Notices and writing from the church, in your own time.

Prayer

Ask for prayer. By default your request goes to your Guide alone. If you tick the box, the whole church can pray for it, and **your name is never shown when they do**.

Your Guide can ask you to pray for them too. It shows at the top of Prayer. Press **I am praying for this** and they are told. If something in it worries you, **Report** is on the same card.

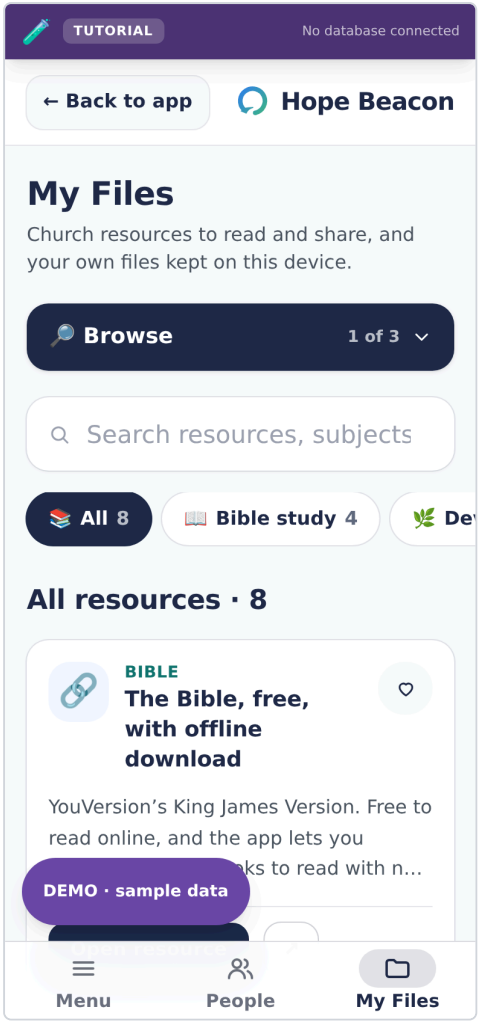


Prayer. Your request goes to your Guide unless you choose otherwise.

Your shelf

Eight things to read and watch, in the order we would hand them to you. A Bible you can read on a phone, then Jesus, then a way into studying for yourself, and then what this church teaches.

Nothing is hidden. Everything your Guide can see, you can find too. This is simply where we would start.



The shelf. Eight resources, and it opens with a Bible and with Jesus.

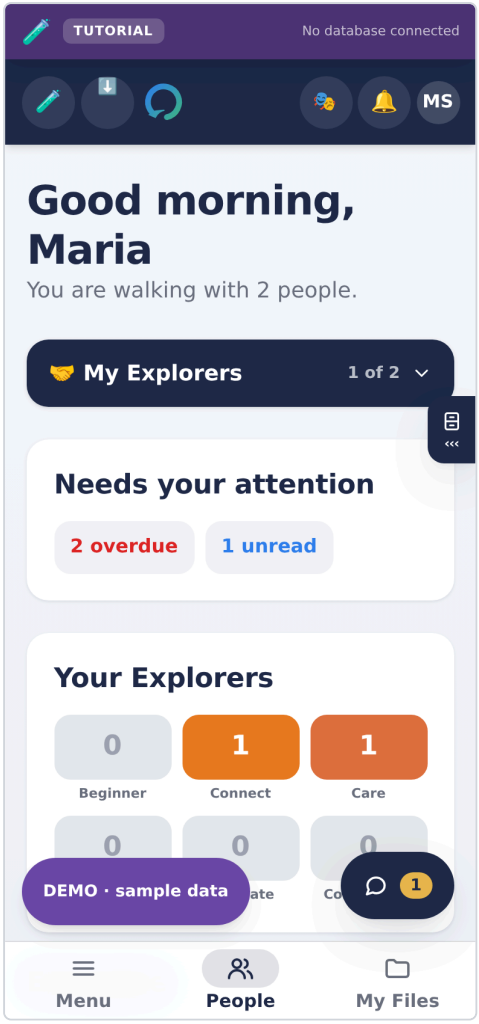
Tap the heart on anything to keep it on your own device, so it opens with no signal.

Part 3 — If you are a Guide

A Guide walks with up to the number of Explorers the church has set. It is a limit the app enforces, not a suggestion: somebody carrying forty names is not walking with anybody.

Your desk

Everyone you walk with, and what needs you today.



A Guide's desk. Who you walk with, and what is waiting.

Talking with somebody

Open a person and press **Message**, or use the round **Talk** button in the corner. It is private between the two of you. You can attach a photograph or a file, and photographs are made smaller and have their location removed before they are sent. Replying, reacting and voice messages work as they do for an Explorer (Part 2).

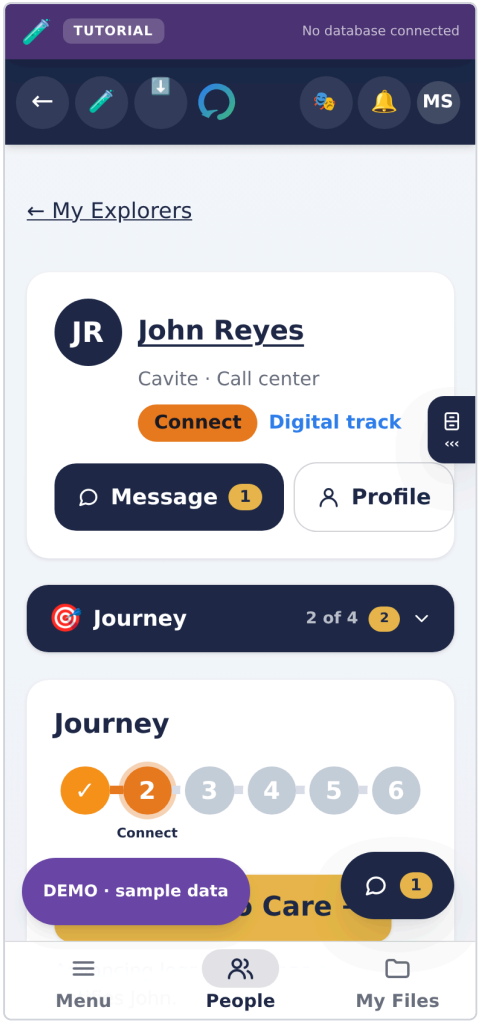


A conversation. The line at the top says it: only the two people walking together can read it.

Prayer runs both ways. On a person's **Care** tab you can read what they asked and tell them you are praying, and ask them to pray for you. Only they see what you ask, and you see when they are praying for it.

Moving somebody along

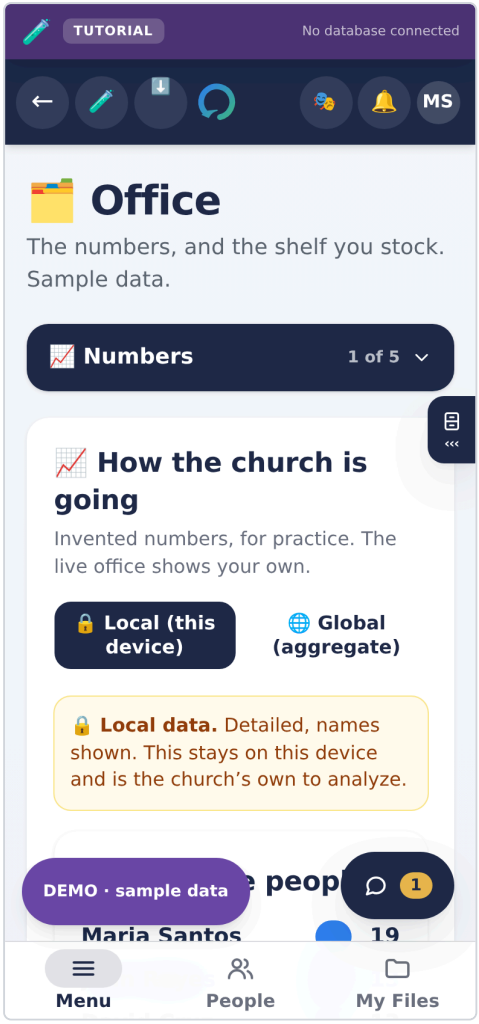
The Journey tab is where you record where somebody has reached, and send them the next lesson.



The journey. Where somebody has reached, and what comes next.

The Office

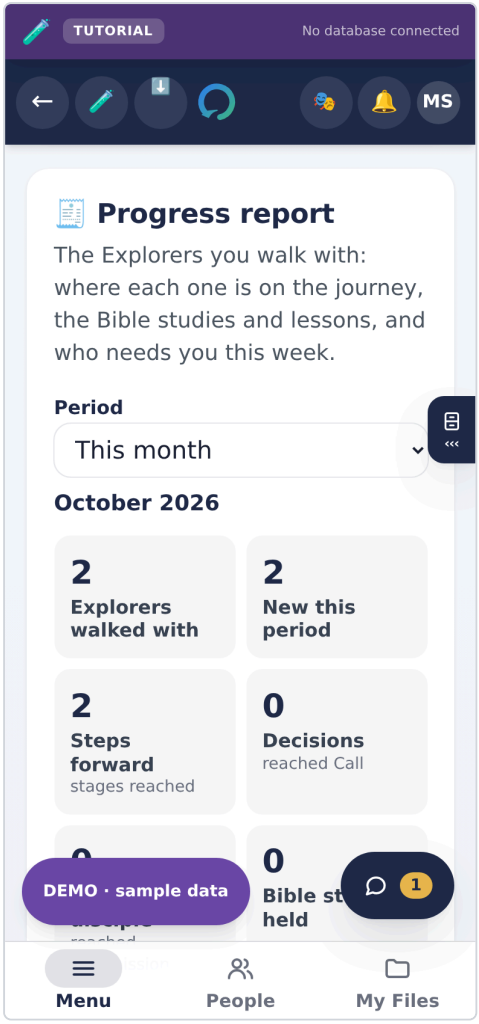
Everything that is your work rather than your conversation: lesson studies, the Sabbath program, evangelistic meetings, resources, the Guides' room, putting a name forward, and your progress report. Each is a subroom, so you tap once and you are there.



The Office in the sample church, open on Numbers. The sample has five of its folders; your church's Office has them all.

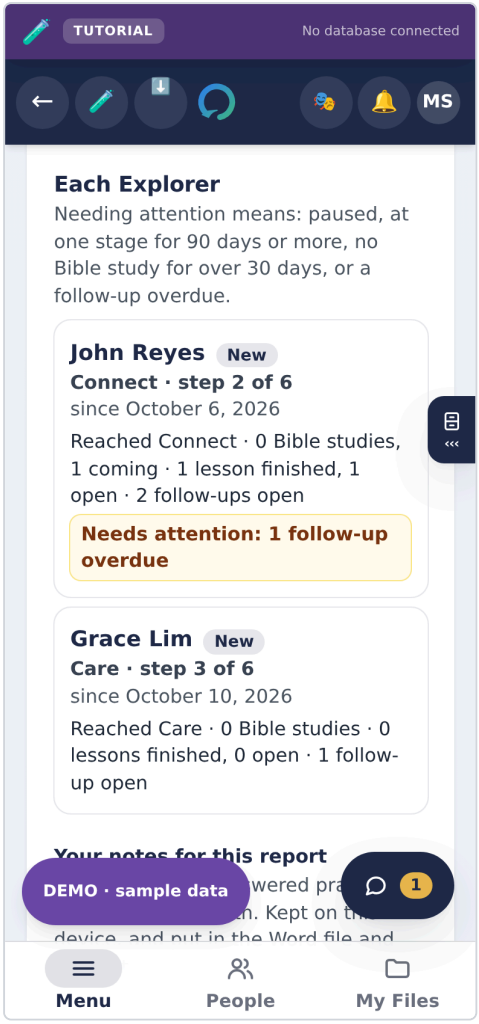
Your progress report

Reports, in the Office, shows how the Explorers you walk with are doing, for this month, last month, this quarter or last quarter. Choose one under **Period**.



The progress report. How many you walk with, who moved a step, and the Bible studies held.

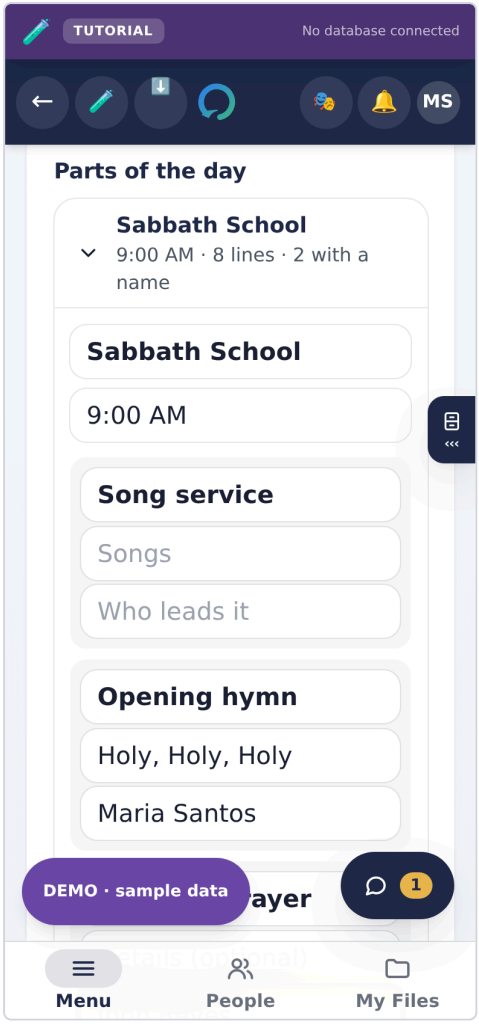
- The numbers at the top: how many you walk with, who is new, the steps forward, decisions, Bible studies held, lessons finished and follow-ups done.
- **Each Explorer**: where they are on the journey and what this month held. Anybody who needs you comes first, with the reason in words, such as "1 follow-up overdue" or "No Bible study for 35 days".
- **Your notes for this report**: what the numbers miss, such as an answered prayer. They stay on your phone and go into the Word file.
- **Download Word file** or **Copy as text** to hand it in.



Each Explorer, and who needs attention.

The Sabbath program

The **Sabbath program** folder in the Office plans a Sabbath's order of service. Press **New program**. It starts with Sabbath School, the Divine Service, the afternoon program and sunset vespers, ready for names. Type who leads each part, and the hymn or passage if you like. Tap a part of the day to open it. Under the date it says how many lines still need somebody.



The Sabbath program. Each line says what happens, which hymn or passage, and who leads it.

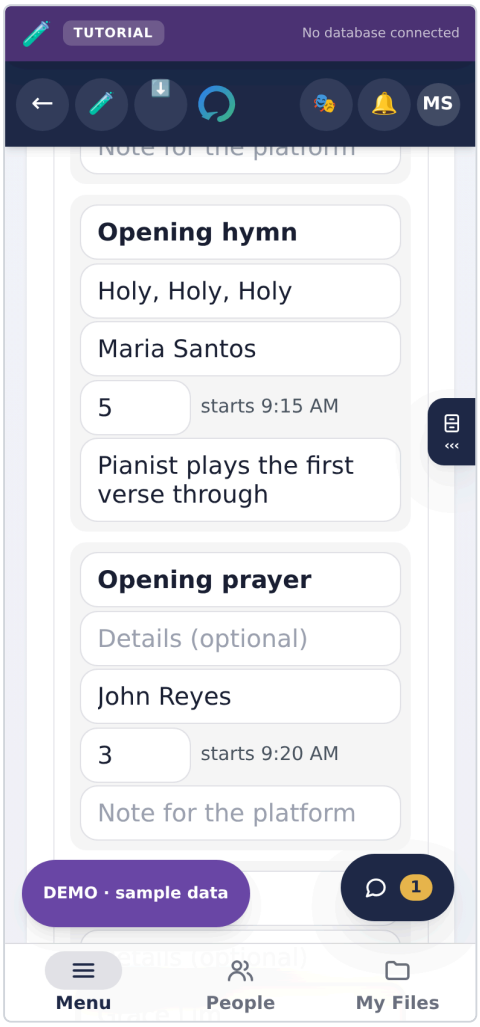
- **Download Word file** gives you a file that opens in Word, in Pages, and in Google Docs (upload it to Google Drive, or open it in the Google Docs app).
- **Download picture** gives you a picture of the program for a group chat. On a phone, **Share the picture** sends it straight to Messenger, Viber or email.
- **Copy as text** is for pasting into a group chat.
- **Post it**, under **Share in the app**, puts it in the app for the people you walk with, or for everyone in the church. They find it on **This Sabbath**, in the Menu.
- **Reuse next week** starts next week's program from this one, names and all.
- **Arrange lines**, under a part, is for moving a line or taking it out.
- **Folder** keeps programs in order: type a name such as "Quarter 4", and the list groups them.
- **Add to calendar** puts each part of the day that has a time on your phone's calendar.

To design it in Canva, a free account is enough. In Canva, choose **Upload** and add the picture or the Word file. The app does not connect to Canva.

Advanced settings, a tick box above your programs, adds more:

- **Minutes** for each line, so each line shows when it starts. If one part runs into the next, the program tells you.

- **A note** on any line, for the people on the platform. Choose **For the platform, with times and notes** before you download to get a copy with them. The copy for the congregation, the picture and the post never have the notes.
- **Your own details**, for anything the boxes do not cover, such as "Deacons on duty". Press **Add a detail**, give it a name, and write what it says. It prints under the theme.
- **Save as a template**, to start next time from your own layout.
- **Reminders**: everyone named, each with a message ready to copy and send.



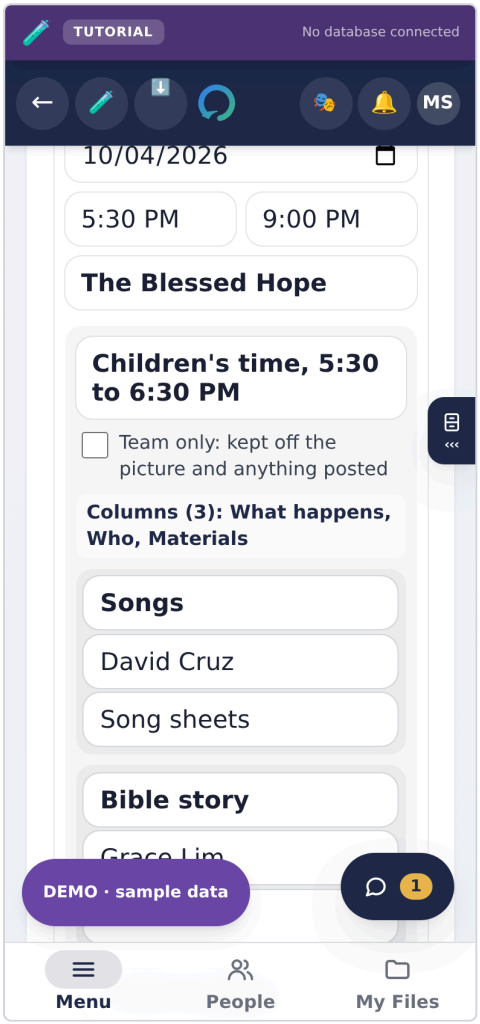
Advanced settings. Each line has its minutes, when it starts, and a note for the platform.

Your programs are saved on your phone or computer as you type, and work with no signal. In your church's app they also follow you to any phone or computer where you sign in. Nobody else sees them until you post them or download them. Directors have the same folder.

Evangelistic meetings

The **Evangelistic meetings** folder in the Office plans a series of meetings your own way. Press **New meetings**, choose the first night and how many nights, then **Start with a plan** or **Start blank**. The plan gives each night from 5:30 to 9:00 PM: children's time (songs, a Bible story, craft making), health time, Bible study, and snacks, plus a team and a to-do list. Change any of it.

- Tap a night to open it. Give it a date, when it starts and ends, and a topic.
- **Add a block** puts a program, a team, a schedule, a list, a paragraph or a checklist on a night or on the whole series. **Arrange blocks** moves them.
- A list's **Columns** lets you name its columns yourself, up to six.
- **Copy to a new night** makes the next night from this one.
- **Its look** chooses a colour, a heading style, and where the name sits, for the Word file and the picture.
- Tick **Team only** on anything that is not for the public. It stays out of the picture and anything you post.
- **Folder** keeps many series in order, such as "Youth Week".



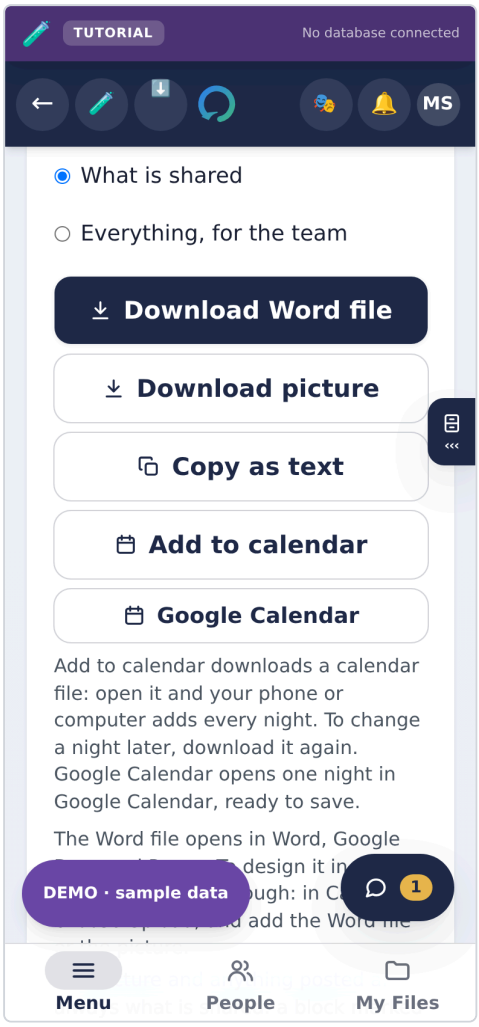
Evangelistic meetings. A night's children's time, with a column you added yourself.

Under **Take it away**, choose the whole series or one night, then download a Word file or a picture, or **Post it** for the people you walk with or the whole church.

On your calendar, and on your other devices

Add to calendar downloads a calendar file. Open it and your phone or computer adds every night (or each part of a Sabbath program that has a time). On an iPhone it is one tap. On a computer, Google Calendar takes it under **Settings**, **Import**. If you change a night, download it again.

Google Calendar appears when you choose one night: it opens Google Calendar with that night filled in, ready to save.

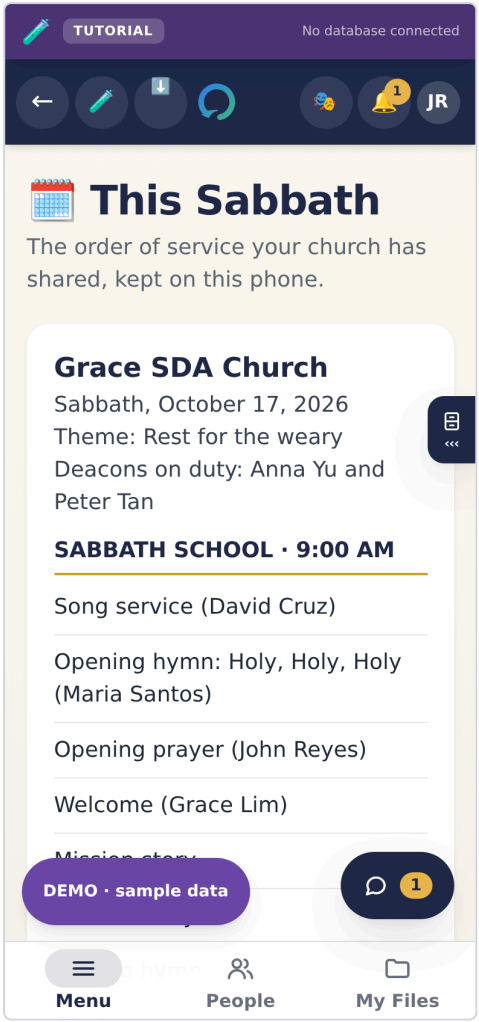


Add to calendar and Google Calendar, under Take it away.

On another phone or computer, sign in with the same account and open the Office: in your church's app, your programs and meetings are there. Under **Saved** it says whether they have reached your account yet. With no signal, they wait on the phone and go up by themselves when the signal comes back.

This Sabbath

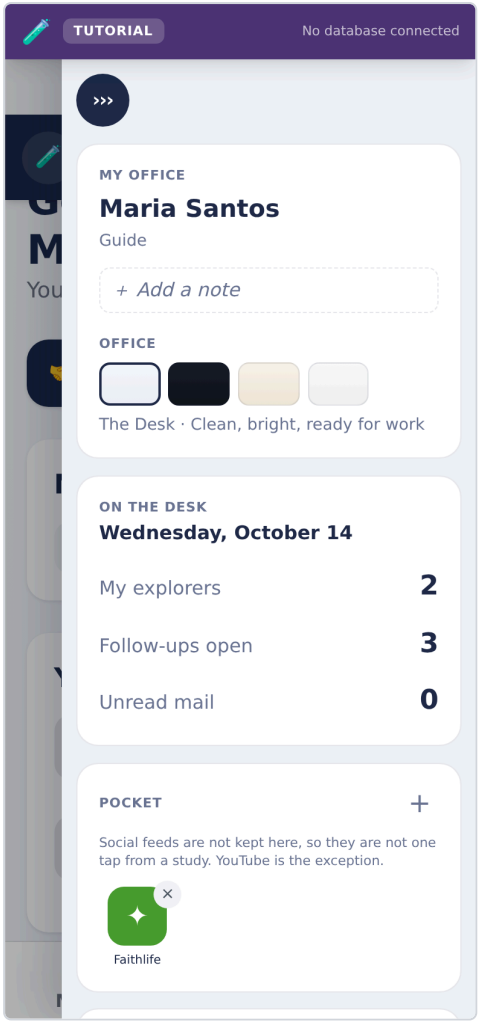
This Sabbath, in the Menu, shows the Sabbath program your Guide or your church has posted, with who shared it, and any evangelistic meetings they have posted. Once you have opened it with a signal, it opens again with none, so you can read it in a church hall without signal.



This Sabbath on a phone. The church, the date, the theme, then each part of the day and who leads it.

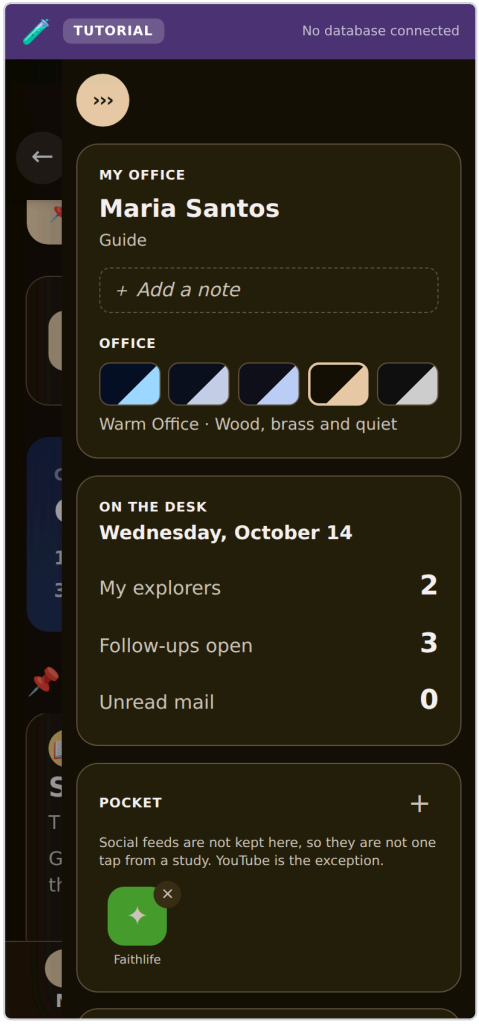
Your desk drawer

On a phone, your desk is a drawer. Tap the small cabinet on the right edge, or swipe in from that edge: the date, what is waiting, a note to yourself, and a pocket of links. Tap ››› to put it away.



The desk drawer, open: today's date, what is waiting, a note, and the pocket.

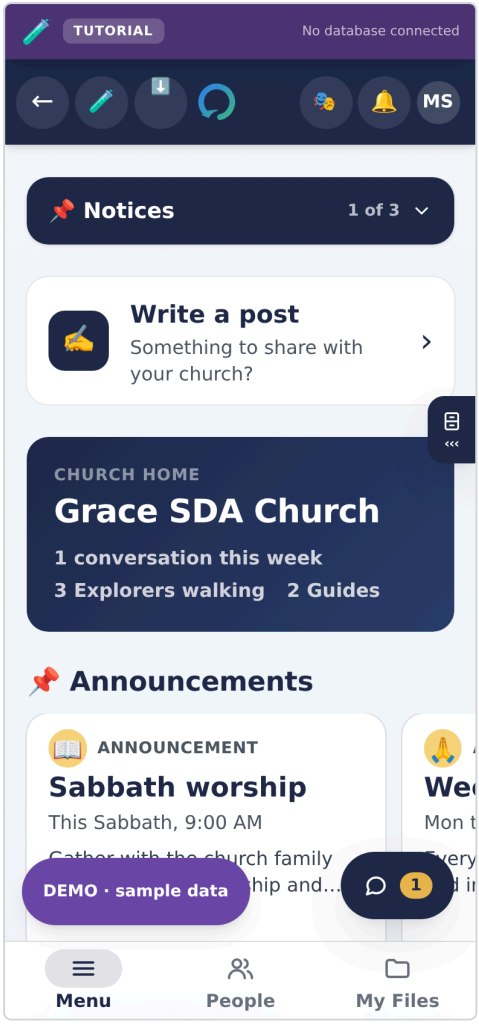
The colour squares at the top of your desk change the colours of the whole app. They work in every look. The first square is the look's own colours, so you can always go back. In Focus, which is dark, a colour stays dark: Warm Office becomes a warm evening brown. Each look remembers its own choice.



The desk under Focus with Warm Office chosen: the whole page turns a warm dark brown.

Writing for the church

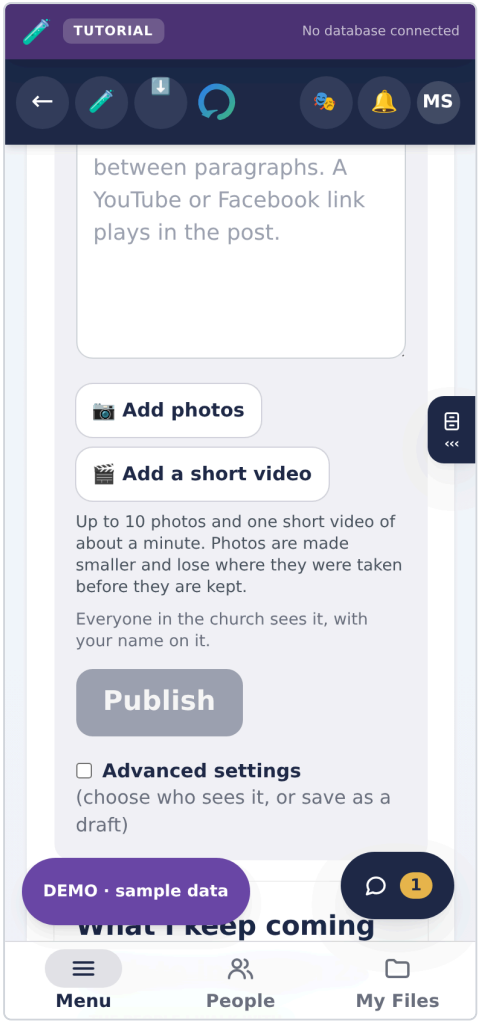
On **Home**, press **Write a post**, near the top. The writing box opens with the cursor already in **Title**: give it a title, write, and press **Publish**. Everybody in the church reads it, with your name on it, and the box says so once it has gone.



Home opens with Write a post near the top.

That is all most posts need. Under **Publish**, **Advanced settings** is there if you want it: send the post only to the people you walk with, or to people you choose, or **Save as draft** to finish it later. You never have to open it.

The same box is in Home's **Blog** folder, with what the church wrote below it.



Write a post: a title, the post, Publish, and Advanced settings under it if you want it.

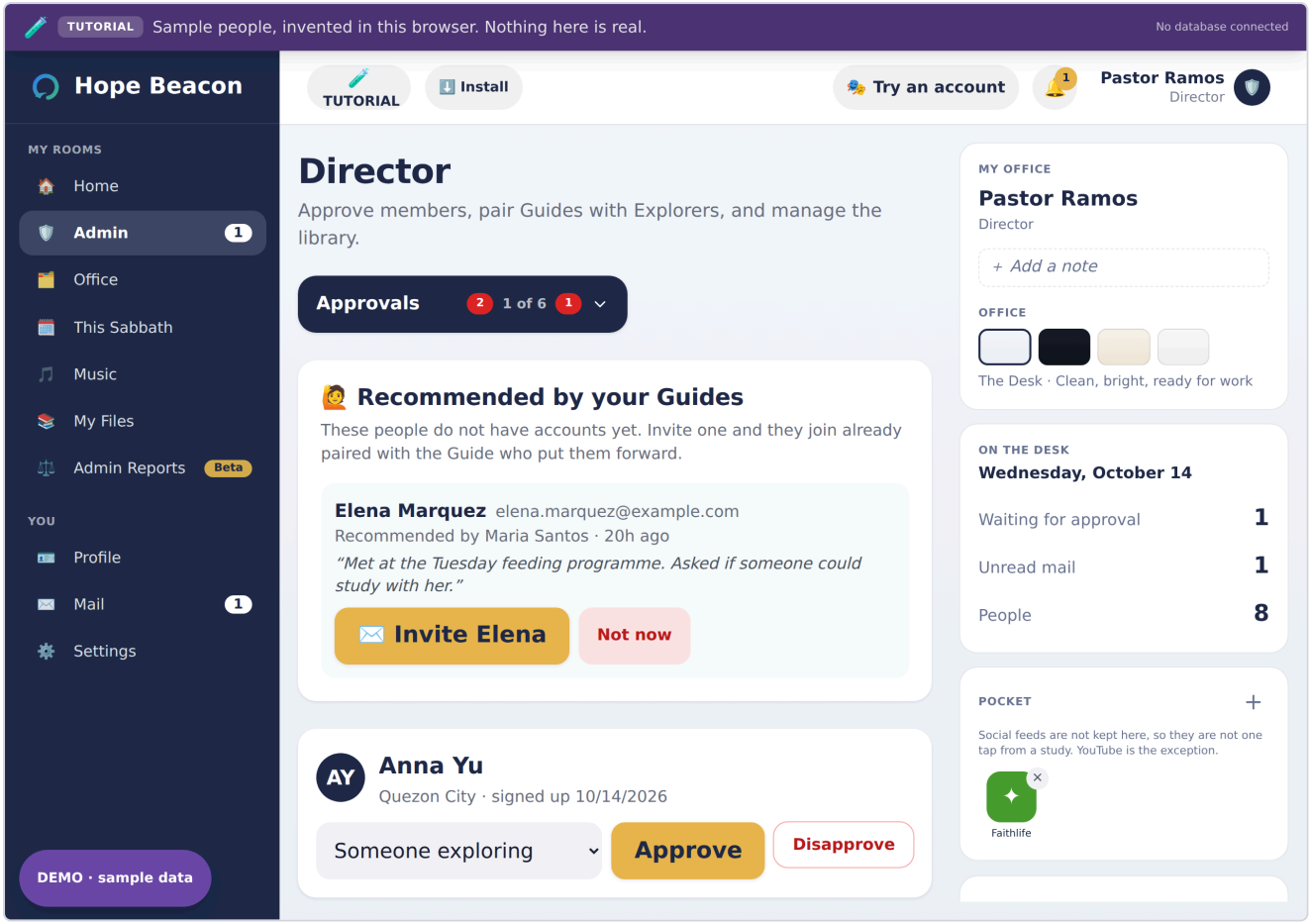
To pin a notice at the top of everybody's Home, open Home's folder button and choose **Announcements**: a title, the words, **Pin it**. **Advanced settings** adds when it happens, such as "This Sabbath, 9:00 AM". Take a notice down from **Notices**, beside the notice itself.

Part 4 — If you are a Director

Directors run the church's account: who gets in, and who walks with whom.

Who is waiting

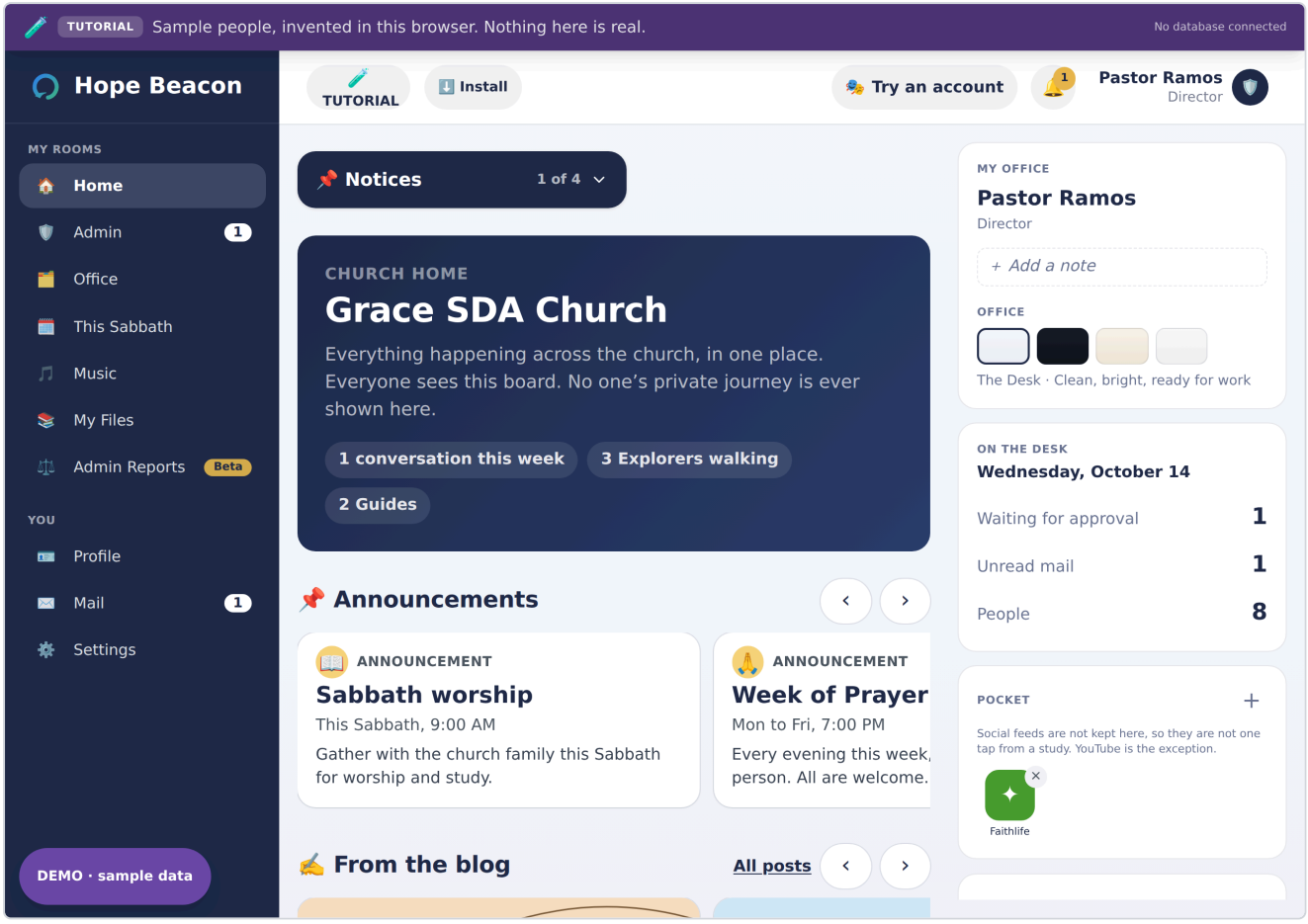
The single most important screen in the app. **An Explorer with no Guide has no app**, so anything above zero here is somebody being ignored.



Approvals. Who is waiting to be let in, and who is waiting to be paired.

The church home

Notices, your **Blog**, **Announcements**, the prayer wall, and the numbers.



The church home.

Four questions, once a week, five minutes:

1. Is anybody unpaired?
2. Is any Guide at their limit of five while Explorers wait?
3. Is any guild flagged "Needs a look"?
4. Is there anything in the trial room?

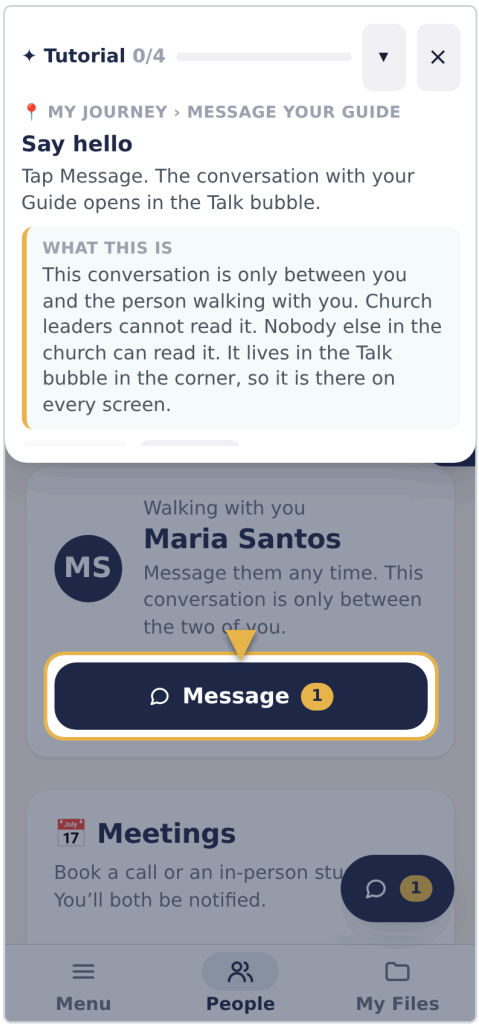
Without that rhythm the numbers are decoration.

The progress report

Reports, in the Office, shows every Explorer in the church by stage and by Guide, for a month or a quarter, with who needs somebody to look. Bible studies, lessons and follow-ups stay between each Guide and Explorer, so they are in each Guide's own report, not yours. Ask a Guide for theirs.

Part 5 — The guided walk

If you would rather be shown than told, the app will walk you through your own part of it. Pick who you are on the front door and follow the highlight. It points at the next thing to tap, and explains what it is before you tap it.



The guided walk. It highlights the next thing, and says what it is for.

It takes two or three minutes, uses safe sample data, and nothing you press reaches a real person.

If something looks wrong

- **A blank screen, or something out of place after an update.** Close the app fully and open it again. It checks for a new version each time it starts.
- **You cannot find a button somebody told you about.** Check which folder you are in. Tap the button at the top of the screen; what you want may be in another folder.
- **The app says your invitation is not valid.** Invitations expire. Ask your church for a new one.
- **You changed your profile picture and the old one is still showing.** Close and reopen the app once.

Anything else, use **Send feedback** at the bottom of the front door. It takes a sentence.